A SCIENCE INFORMED EDUCATIONAL COMIC

THE SMALL CHANGES MANUAL

An ordinary life. A few useful changes.





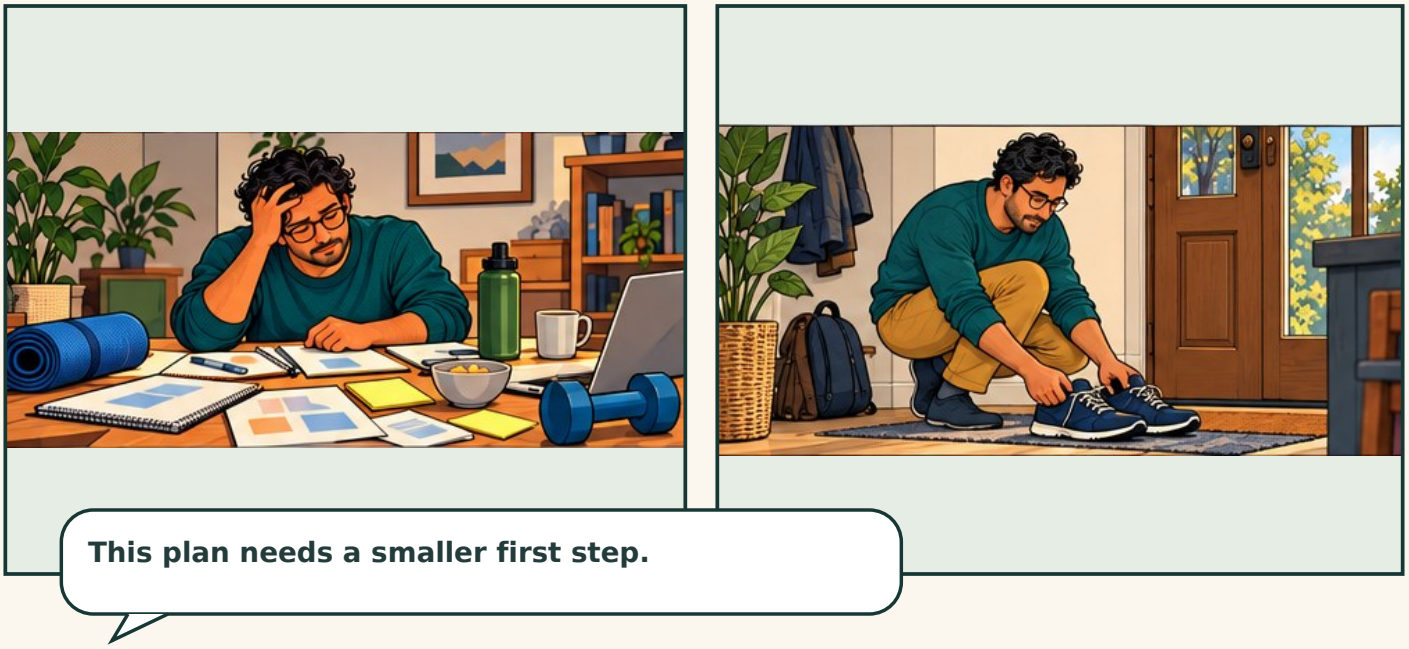


SLEEP MOVE FOCUS CONNECT

35 illustrated pages / A flexible four week starter plan

START HERE

You do not need a new personality



Alex has work, messages, meals and unfinished jobs. This fictional story follows small decisions, including the days they do not work.

Hard to keep going	Make the start easier / page 4
Tired most mornings	Make room for sleep / page 8
Too much sitting	Build ordinary movement / page 12
Always interrupted	Protect one useful task / page 16
Stress or disconnection	Pause and make room for people / page 19

FOR EDUCATION

Use one idea at a time. This is general education, not diagnosis or treatment. AI helped create the text and pictures. Scientific sources are numbered; book influences use B labels.

Independent project. No endorsement by the named authors or organisations. Educational purpose does not remove copyright obligations. Full details are in the accompanying audit.

A useful idea still needs evidence



STRONG EVIDENCE

Consistent substantial research or established guidance for the stated claim.

MIXED EVIDENCE

Some support, with important limits or disagreement.

EARLY EVIDENCE

Too little reliable research to be confident.

SUPPORTED PRINCIPLE

Regular physical activity benefits health. [9]

OUR STARTER EXAMPLE

Take a comfortable five-minute walk. Five minutes is a starting choice, not a complete health dose.

Labels are editorial judgements, not formal clinical grades. A full therapy is not the same as a one-minute exercise. A laboratory task is not an entire working day. An association does not prove cause.

When a diagram is a concept sketch, its shapes are illustrative. Alex is a fictional teaching example, not a study participant or a promise of results.

Motivation has busy days too





After lunch, I can put my shoes on.

Sunday Alex promises an hour of exercise. Monday brings a late meeting. On Tuesday the plan gets a smaller starting point.

1 **Lunch ends** > 2 **Shoes go on** > 3 **Step outside**

MIXED EVIDENCE / habit formation

THE SCIENCE

Repeated actions in a stable setting can become more automatic. Habit studies vary greatly, and many rely on people rating their own habits. There is no reliable deadline for everyone. [1]

WHY IT HELPS

A clear cue gives the action a place in the day. A small start makes the first attempt more manageable; two minutes is a design choice.

THE SMALL CHANGE

After putting the lunch plate away, walk for two minutes. Use an event that usually happens.

TRY IT TODAY

Finish this sentence: After I ___, I will ___. Choose something you can do on a difficult day.

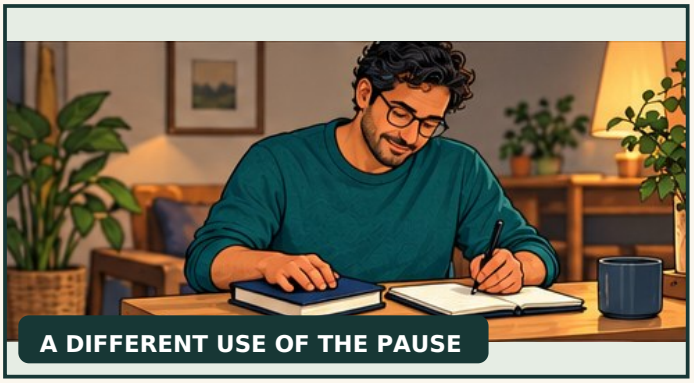
IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If your days vary, use an event rather than a clock time. If the cue rarely happens, choose a different cue.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [1].

Notice what starts the action





What did I pick it up for?

Alex picks up the phone while the kettle boils. The phone was already beside the mug.



MIXED EVIDENCE / cue based habits

THE SCIENCE

Cues in a familiar setting can prompt repeated actions. A cue-action-payoff sketch is a useful teaching model, not a complete account of the brain or all behaviour. [1]

WHY IT HELPS

The immediate payoff matters to Alex: a short interesting page feels worth doing. A reward need not be food, money or a screen.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Leave a book beside the mug. Put the phone somewhere that requires a deliberate trip.

TRY IT TODAY

For one unwanted habit, note the setting, the action and what you get from it. Look for the need underneath.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If checking brings needed contact or relief, plan a useful replacement. Moving an object alone may not address loneliness, stress or work demands.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [1].

Make the next step easier





Alex wants to walk, but the shoes are buried. The remote is within reach.

Search + decide + prepare

Shoes ready + step out

MIXED EVIDENCE / if then planning

THE SCIENCE

An if-then plan can help turn intentions into action. A research review supports planning a specific response to a specific situation; results vary by goal and setting. [2]

WHY IT HELPS

Preparation removes one decision. Clear and Fogg both stress making desired actions easier. This room setup is our practical example, not a separately proven formula. [B1] [B2]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Place shoes by the door. Say: if lunch ends, then I put them on and step outside.

TRY IT TODAY

Remove one obstacle from a useful action. Add one small obstacle to a distraction. Keep emergency and accessibility needs in mind.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If the action still stalls, ask whether time, money, pain or another person is the real barrier. A better cue cannot solve every constraint.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [2].

Keep a version for hard days





The short version counts as starting.

Rain starts just as Alex reaches the door. Today the short sheltered route is enough. Tomorrow can be different.

START

REPEAT

BUILD

STARTER DESIGN / informed by habit research

THE SCIENCE

Repeating an action in a familiar setting can make it feel more automatic. Studies do not establish one tiny action size or a deadline that works for everyone. [1]

WHY IT HELPS

A small version keeps beginning manageable. It is a design tool, not a full health dose. Treat identity as a direction you choose, rather than a test you pass.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Write two versions of one action: a minimum for hard days and a normal version when you have space.

TRY IT TODAY

Write a minimum and a normal version. Example: step outside; or take a longer walk when time allows.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

A tiny action does not deliver the full benefit of regular exercise. It keeps a route open toward a useful amount. Review progress, not just streaks.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [1].

Sleep has two helpers





Sleep comes before another routine.

Alex lies awake early, then feels sleepy during an afternoon call. Being tired is not an on-off switch.

Sleep need builds



The clock changes timing



STRONG EVIDENCE / sleep need and body clock

THE SCIENCE

The need for sleep builds while you are awake. A daily body clock also affects when sleep comes easily. Light helps set that clock. These processes work together. [3]

WHY IT HELPS

Adult guidance recommends at least seven hours of sleep regularly; individual needs differ. Time in bed is not the same as time asleep. [4]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Protect enough time for sleep and choose a realistic waking time you can usually keep.

TRY IT TODAY

Look at tomorrow backwards. When must you wake? What evening task can move earlier to make room for sleep?

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If work or caring duties limit sleep, seek practical support. Do not cut sleep to fit a self-improvement routine. Avoid driving when sleepy.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [3],[4].

Let daytime look like daytime



ALEX TRIES

Find a practical opportunity for daytime light.

Alex used to move from a dim bedroom to a dim desk. Now breakfast includes a little time outside.



STRONG EVIDENCE / light affects body timing

THE SCIENCE

Daytime light and lower evening light support the body clock. Expert recommendations draw on human light studies. A single exact outdoor dose does not fit every season, location or person. [5]

WHY IT HELPS

Outdoor daylight is generally brighter than indoor light. The useful contrast is a brighter day and a darker night, not staring at the sun. [5]

THE SMALL CHANGE

When practical, get outside during the early part of your waking day. Combine it with an existing trip.

TRY IT TODAY

Take your usual morning drink outdoors or walk to a nearby safe spot. Use sun protection as needed.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

Never look at the sun. Night shifts, eye conditions and light-sensitive medicines may need individual advice. If outside is difficult, use your brightest comfortable daytime space.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [5].

Make evening a softer landing





One change this week is enough.

Alex switches off the bright ceiling light and moves the phone to a shelf. The day still feels unfinished. It can end anyway.



STRONG EVIDENCE / caffeine can disrupt sleep

THE SCIENCE

Caffeine can reduce or delay sleep. Effects depend on dose, timing and the person. Research does not justify one universal coffee cutoff for all adults. [6]

WHY IT HELPS

This removes two possible obstacles to sleep. A phone also keeps you engaged; a night setting alone does not make scrolling restful.

THE SMALL CHANGE

If sleep is poor, move your last caffeine earlier or reduce the amount. Lower bright light as bedtime approaches. [5] [6]

TRY IT TODAY

For a week, change only the late caffeine or the evening screen habit. Note sleep and next-day alertness without chasing a perfect score.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If cutting caffeine causes headaches, reduce gradually. Tea and energy drinks can contain caffeine too. You do not need a rigid delay after waking.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [5],[6].

A rough night is information





After another difficult night Alex stops adding sleep gadgets. The next step is a simpler room and, if the problem continues, proper help.

1 **One rough night** > 2 **Gentle adjustment** > 3 **Ongoing / seek care**

STRONG EVIDENCE / CBT I for chronic insomnia

THE SCIENCE

A quiet, dark, comfortably cool room and regular timing are sensible sleep supports. Persistent insomnia needs more than sleep hygiene. Structured cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia, CBT-I, is recommended. [7] [8]

WHY IT HELPS

CBT-I changes patterns that keep insomnia going. A self-help bedtime list is not the same as this treatment. [8]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Keep the bedroom comfortable. If awake and frustrated, do something quiet in dim light; return when sleepy. [7] [8]

TRY IT TODAY

Choose one practical room fix: noise, light or uncomfortable temperature. After a poor night, reduce avoidable demands rather than blaming yourself.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

Ask for assessment if sleep problems persist, or if loud snoring, gasping or marked daytime sleepiness occurs. Do not begin a strict sleep-restriction programme alone.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [7],[8].

A walk belongs in ordinary life



ALEX TRIES

Choose a comfortable movement you can repeat.

Alex cannot find a free hour for the gym. There is, however, a short gap after lunch.

1 **Start comfortably** > 2 **Repeat across week** > 3 **Build gradually**

STRONG EVIDENCE / regular physical activity

THE SCIENCE

Any activity is better than none. Adults should build toward 150-300 minutes of moderate activity weekly, or 75-150 vigorous minutes, or a mix. This is a destination, not a first-day demand. [9]

WHY IT HELPS

Moderate effort makes breathing faster while conversation remains possible. Your useful starting level depends on your health and fitness. [9]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Use the lunch cue for a short walk or an accessible form of movement. Build gradually.

TRY IT TODAY

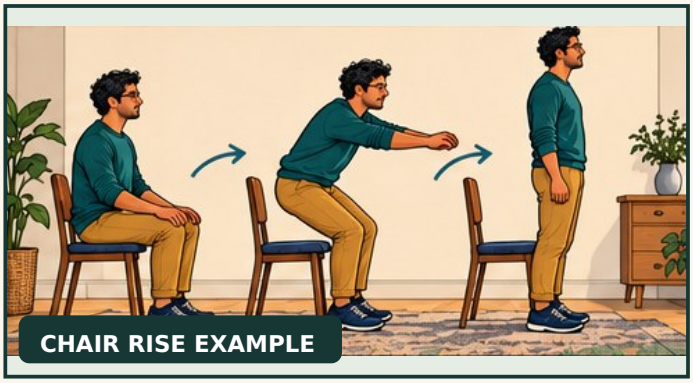
Try a comfortable five-minute outing. If that is too much, shorten it. If it is easy, plan when to repeat it.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

Heat, unsafe streets and disability change the options. Try an indoor route, wheeling or suitable seated movement. New chest pain or faintness needs prompt medical attention.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [9].

Keep everyday strength





Carrying shopping feels harder than Alex expected. Strength is useful far beyond a gym.

1 **Sit with control** > 2 **Stand steadily** > 3 **Adapt and progress**

STRONG EVIDENCE / strengthening recommendation

THE SCIENCE

Guidelines recommend muscle-strengthening work for all major muscle groups on at least two days each week. A few easy moves are a start, not a complete long-term programme. [9]

WHY IT HELPS

These simple examples practise leg and pushing movements. A fuller plan also includes pulling and other muscle groups, with effort that grows gradually.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Practise controlled chair rises and wall push-ups at a comfortable level. Use a stable chair and clear floor.

TRY IT TODAY

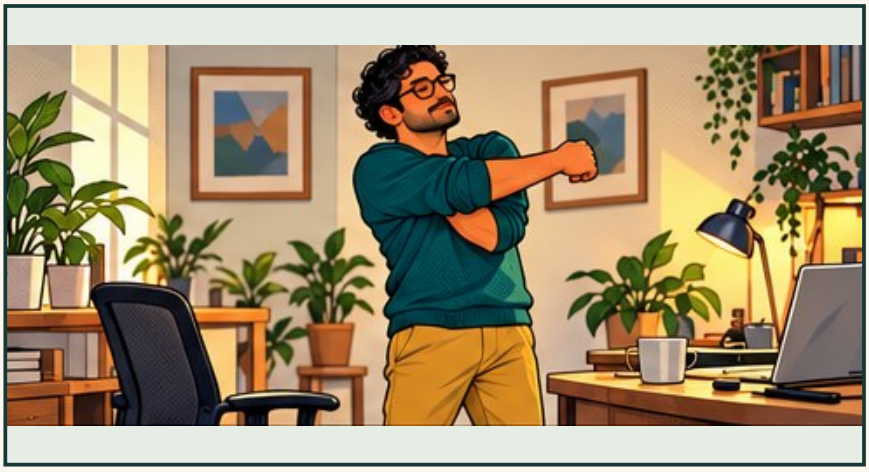
Do a few slow repetitions. Stop before technique becomes shaky. Breathe normally. Ask a qualified instructor how to progress safely if you are unsure.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

Use arm support or a higher chair if needed. Sharp pain is a reason to stop. Recent surgery, unstable illness or major movement limits call for tailored advice.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [9].

Give sitting an interruption



ALEX TRIES

Use a natural pause to change position or move.

The first call ends. Alex stands and moves gently before the next one. It is a small break in an otherwise seated afternoon.

1 **Work seated** > 2 **Natural pause** > 3 **Move or reposition**

STRONG EVIDENCE / less sedentary time

THE SCIENCE

Guidelines advise limiting sedentary time and replacing it with activity of any intensity. They do not set one proven break timer for every adult or job. [9]

WHY IT HELPS

This adds movement without needing a separate session. It supplements regular activity; standing still is not the same as a walk or a strength session.

THE SMALL CHANGE

At a natural pause, stand, stretch or move in a way available to you.

TRY IT TODAY

Tie a brief movement break to finishing a call or getting a drink. Change position when possible.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If standing is difficult, consider comfortable seated movement or a position change. For intensive or safety-critical work, take breaks only when safe. A practical cue is better than another stressful alarm.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [9].

Improve the meal you already eat



ALEX TRIES

Improve one meal you already make.

Alex thinks healthy eating requires a new kitchen and a new diet. Tonight the usual meal gets lentils and vegetables.

1 **Familiar meal** > 2 **Add useful food** > 3 **Drink regularly**

STRONG EVIDENCE / dietary pattern and hydration

THE SCIENCE

A varied diet with vegetables, fruit, pulses, whole grains and appropriate protein sources supports health. Affordable frozen and canned options can help. There is no required superfood. [10]

WHY IT HELPS

Water is an inexpensive drink. Other drinks and food also supply fluid. Needs rise with heat and activity; a fixed large water target is unnecessary. [11]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Add one useful food to a meal you already make. Keep water or another suitable drink within reach.

TRY IT TODAY

Choose one: add beans to a familiar dish, keep fruit visible, or replace a frequent sugary drink with water.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

Allergies, eating disorders and conditions affecting diet or fluid needs require individual guidance. Follow prescribed fluid limits. No detox, fasting window or supplement stack is required here.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [10],[11].

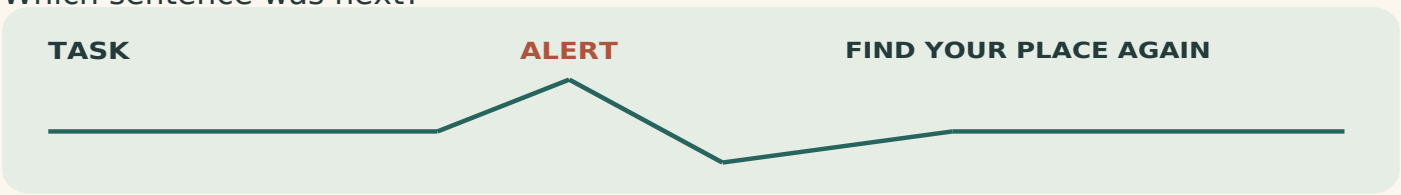
An interruption has a return trip





I need to find my sentence again.

The phone lights up. Alex answers, opens another app, then returns to the document. Which sentence was next?



MIXED EVIDENCE / transfer from attention studies

THE SCIENCE

Phone notifications disrupted performance in a controlled attention task. That supports reducing avoidable alerts, but it does not prove a fixed number of lost minutes for every interruption. [12]

WHY IT HELPS

There are fewer signals asking you to switch. Cal Newport gives protected work a useful place in the day; our short block is an adaptation. [B4]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Silence nonessential alerts for one work period. Put the phone outside easy reach, with necessary contacts allowed through.

TRY IT TODAY

Before starting, write the next visible action: draft the opening paragraph, pay one bill or read two pages.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If your job requires rapid replies, agree a short protected window or choose a quieter task. Do not block medical, caring or emergency contact needs.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [12].

Make one piece of work visible





Open the file. Draft the heading.

Alex changes finish project to open the file and draft one heading. The task finally has a visible beginning.

1 **One visible step**

2 > **Protected block**

3 > **Note next step**

MIXED EVIDENCE / breaks and performance

THE SCIENCE

Short breaks can ease fatigue and improve vigour. A review found less consistent effects on performance. No single work-break ratio is established as best for everyone. [13]

WHY IT HELPS

A clear beginning reduces planning during the block. A break can mean stretching or looking away, rather than opening a feed. The exact schedule is an experiment.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Choose one task, close unrelated tabs and try a manageable work block. Then pause and check what you need.

TRY IT TODAY

Try ten minutes of one task. At the end, write a restart note before a brief break. Extend only if useful.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If the block fails, reduce the task or remove a barrier. Ongoing attention difficulties may need support or assessment, not a stricter timer.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [13].

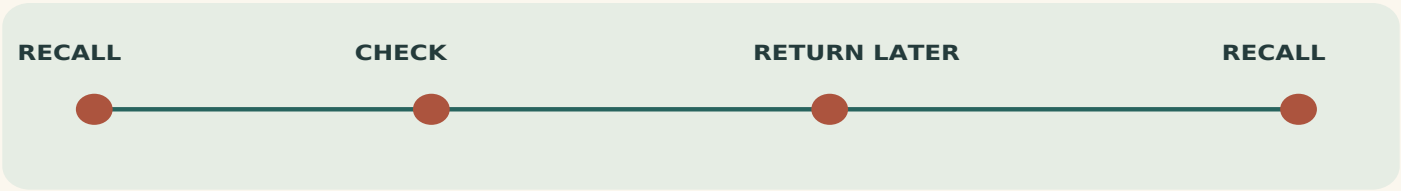
Remember by trying to remember



ALEX TRIES

Close the page, recall, then check.

Alex rereads a page and recognises every line. With the book closed, the main idea disappears.



STRONG EVIDENCE / retrieval and spacing

THE SCIENCE

Practice recalling information improves learning compared with restudy in many studies. Spacing study over time also helps retention. Much of this evidence comes from education and memory tasks. [14] [15]

WHY IT HELPS

Recall tests what you can bring to mind. Checking prevents mistakes from being left uncorrected. Brown, Roediger and McDaniel explain these learning principles in Make It Stick. [B5]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Close the page. Explain the idea in your own words. Reopen it, check and correct what you missed.

TRY IT TODAY

Without looking back, name one change from this book and why it may help. Revisit it tomorrow and later in the week.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If you remember little, use a small prompt or shorter section. For a physical skill, practise the skill too. Our revisit schedule is an example, not a proven optimum.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [14],[15].

Turn down the effort for a moment





I can reply after a pause.

An urgent email makes Alex tense. Before answering, Alex pauses. The problem still needs a reply. It does not need the first angry reply.

1 **Notice tension** > 2 **Gentle slow breath** > 3 **Choose next action**

MIXED EVIDENCE / breathing for stress

THE SCIENCE

Stress can prepare the body to act. Breathing trials suggest modest average reductions in self-reported stress, but many studies have bias concerns. A brief pause is not a cure. [16] [20]

WHY IT HELPS

A comfortable breathing rhythm may help you settle enough to choose the next action. The aim is not to erase every feeling or reset a hormone.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Sit safely. Let your shoulders soften. Breathe gently and a little more slowly, without forcing deep breaths.

TRY IT TODAY

Try a minute, without breath holds. Then ask: what needs action, what can wait, and what support would help?

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If you feel dizzy or more anxious, stop controlling the breath. Notice your feet or name objects around you instead. Persistent stress may require changes to demands, not more exercises.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [16],[20].

A thought is not an instruction





That thought can be here. I can still choose.

A missed walk becomes the thought I always fail. Alex notices the thought and leaves the shoes beside the door for the next chance.

I always fail

NOTICE THE THOUGHT

Choose one useful action

MIXED EVIDENCE / brief exercise extrapolated from ACT

THE SCIENCE

Acceptance and commitment therapy, ACT, can help with several clinical problems. Evidence for a full therapy does not prove that a single phrase has the same effect. [17]

WHY IT HELPS

The wording creates a little room to respond. Russ Harris popularises this approach. Acceptance means making room for a feeling; it does not mean accepting harm. [B6]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Try: I am noticing the thought that I always fail. Then choose one small action that matters to you.

TRY IT TODAY

Name the feeling without arguing with it. Pick a kind, useful next step, even if the feeling stays.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

You do not have to do this exercise. If distress persists, worsens or disrupts daily life, seek qualified help. If you cannot stay safe, contact local emergency services or urgent care.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [17].

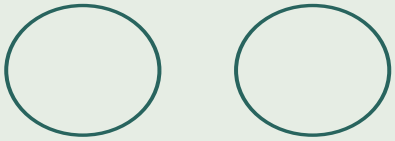
Connection needs a little space





Would you like help or company?

Alex puts the phone away while a friend talks. This time the first response is a question, not a solution.



TIME + ATTENTION

Quality and safety matter

STRONG EVIDENCE / association not proven causation

THE SCIENCE

Stronger social relationships are linked with better survival in longitudinal research. These studies are largely observational: they do not prove that a daily call extends life. [18]

WHY IT HELPS

Waldinger and Schulz emphasise relationships in The Good Life. Time together can offer support, but relationship quality and your circumstances matter. A larger contact list is not the goal. [B7]

THE SMALL CHANGE

Give one safe person a small, specific invitation: a short walk, a call or tea together.

TRY IT TODAY

Ask one open question. Listen to the answer before giving advice. If useful, ask whether they want help or just company.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If one person is unavailable, try another time or a shared activity. Harmful relationships need boundaries and support. Reconnecting is an option, never an obligation.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [18].

Make room for something that matters



ALEX TRIES

There is room for music too.

Alex picks up a guitar for a few minutes. The washing is still waiting. There is room for something enjoyable without finishing everything first.

1 **What matters** > 2 **One small action** > 3 **A place this week**

PRACTICAL EXERCISE / informed by ACT

THE SCIENCE

ACT uses values to guide action even when feelings are difficult. Evidence for therapy does not establish a universal happiness recipe or prove this worksheet alone improves health. [17] [B6]

WHY IT HELPS

A value is a direction you can act on. A goal can be finished. Being a caring friend can guide many different goals.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Choose one direction you care about: learning, kindness, creativity, family, community or another value. Give it a small place this week.

TRY IT TODAY

Complete this: I want to make room for ___, so this week I will ___. Make the action realistic.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If nothing feels meaningful, start with something you once liked or a safe person. Persistent loss of interest deserves assessment. You are allowed rest without making it productive.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram / research [17].

Choose the bottleneck first





Which change actually helped?

Four weeks later, Alex still misses days. The difference is the next decision: make the action smaller, ask for help, or restart at the next chance.

Many possible changes

One useful choice

One small start

Review before adding more

EDITORIAL SYSTEM / not a validated intervention

THE SCIENCE

The foundations on these pages have different evidence bases. Combining them does not create a newly proven programme. This manual is a practical synthesis, not a clinical trial.

WHY IT HELPS

Our priority is relevance, evidence, effort, cost and safety. More habits are not automatically better. The starter versions are bridges toward useful amounts, not substitutes for them.

THE SMALL CHANGE

Choose the problem causing the most trouble now. Keep one small action until it fits; add another only when ready.

TRY IT TODAY

Poor sleep opportunity? Start on page 8. Little movement? Page 12. Frequent interruptions? Page 16. Too much strain? Page 19.

IF IT DOES NOT FIT

If the problem is money, unsafe housing, workload or illness, seek practical and professional support where possible. Personal routines cannot remove every cause.

FICTIONAL SCENE / AI illustration. Original teaching diagram.

Sleep and one tiny habit



I will keep one cue.

Keep earlier changes small. Stay with this week longer if needed.

01	Choose a realistic waking time and protect sleep opportunity.
02	Choose one cue that already happens most days.
03	Attach a very small action to that cue.
04	Make one evening room or lighting change.
05	Notice late caffeine; change it only if useful.
06	Repeat the same small action. Do not add a new one.
07	Review what fitted. Make the plan easier if needed.

MINIMUM	Prepare for bed by putting the phone away.
NORMAL DAY	Keep a short wind-down and a realistic wake time.
MISSED IT	Resume at the next evening cue. No catch-up routine.

Track whether you made room for sleep, not whether sleep was perfect. [4] [7]

Movement and daily energy



I will move where it fits.

Keep earlier changes small. Stay with this week longer if needed.

08	Keep the sleep change if it is helping.
09	Choose a short accessible walk or movement cue.
10	Repeat it at a comfortable pace.
11	Try a few controlled strength movements.
12	Notice one long sitting spell and interrupt it safely.
13	Repeat the movement you enjoyed most.
14	Review effort and recovery before increasing anything.

MINIMUM	Move comfortably for one minute.
NORMAL DAY	Take a short walk; build toward weekly activity and strength guidance.
MISSED IT	Use the next safe gap. Do not double tomorrow to repay today.

The aim is a starting pattern. A few minutes alone are below full activity targets. [9]

Focus and fewer distractions



Keep earlier changes small. Stay with this week longer if needed.

15	Keep earlier changes at a manageable size.
16	Choose one task that matters. Name its first step.
17	Silence one avoidable source of alerts.
18	Try one short block on that task.
19	Leave a restart note before a break.
20	Recall one thing you learned, then check it.
21	Review what helped you finish a useful piece of work.

MINIMUM	Open the task and do its first small step.
NORMAL DAY	Use one protected work block with a comfortable break.
MISSED IT	Write the next step; use the next available work period.

Block length is adjustable. Ten minutes is an example, not a brain rule. [12] [13] [14] [15]

Stress connection and keeping going



I will keep what helps.

Keep earlier changes small. Stay with this week longer if needed.

22	Keep what helps; pause anything that adds strain.
23	Try a gentle settling pause if you want one.
24	Notice a difficult thought without treating it as an order.
25	Invite a safe person to talk or walk.
26	Make a small space for something you value.
27	Rehearse your busy-day version before you need it.
28	Choose what to keep next month. Drop the rest.

MINIMUM	Pause once or send one caring message.
NORMAL DAY	Choose a settling pause or an unhurried conversation.
MISSED IT	Return at the next suitable moment; repeat this week if useful.

You do not have to add everything. Twenty-eight days starts an experiment; it does not guarantee a habit. [1] [16] [18]

KEEP THIS PAGE

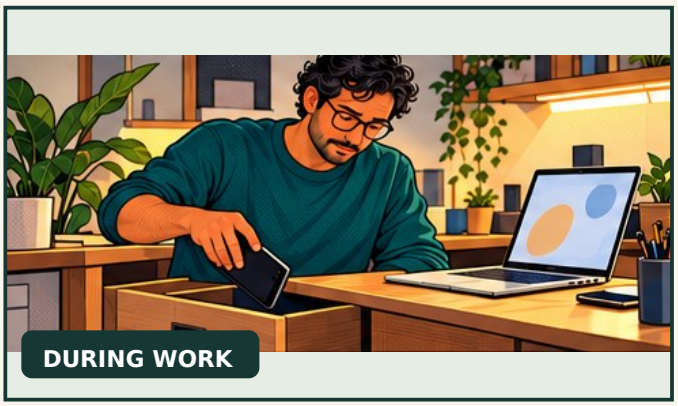
An ordinary day with room to breathe



Make room for daylight and enough sleep. [3] [4] [5]



Do the small version of your chosen action. [1] [2]



Protect one task. Pause when useful. [12] [13]



Move, improve a familiar meal and drink regularly. [9] [10] [11]



Give someone your attention or act on a value. [17] [18]



Lower bright light. Keep late caffeine in mind. [5] [6] [7]

These are opportunities, not six daily obligations. For night shifts, adapt around your main sleep with professional guidance when needed.

PRINT OR FILL ON SCREEN

Four weeks to notice what fits

Choose ONE action each week. Mark M for minimum, S for standard, R for planned rest, or leave blank. You can type into the PDF fields or print the page.

WEEK 1 My action

1	2	3	4	5	6	7

WEEK 2 My action

8	9	10	11	12	13	14

WEEK 3 My action

15	16	17	18	19	20	21

WEEK 4 My action

22	23	24	25	26	27	28

MY CUE

Review once a week: What helped? What got in the way? What can become easier? A blank box does not need to be repaid.

A missed day needs a next step





Today needs a smaller plan.

Alex misses three days while caring for family. The plan changes to fit the day. There is no catch-up workout and no debt to repay.

Do I have the capacity today?

NO

Rest or get support

Illness, exhaustion and urgent caring needs can take priority.

YES

Use the minimum

Choose one safe, manageable action at the next suitable cue.

If the same barrier keeps returning

Change the cue, action or support. Keep the plan useful.

Original planning aid, not a validated treatment decision tool. Seek care for persistent symptoms or marked difficulty functioning.

THE TEN THINGS WORTH REMEMBERING

The useful ideas fit on one page

01 Start with one problem

Choose the change most relevant to your day.

02 Give the action a place

Attach it to a familiar event. [1] [2]

03 Prepare the beginning

Keep the object ready and a small fallback. [B1] [B2]

04 Make room for sleep

Most adults need at least seven hours regularly. [4]

05 Use light sensibly

Brighter days and dimmer evenings support timing. [5]

06 Build ordinary movement

Progress toward activity and strength guidance. [9]

07 Protect one piece of work

Reduce avoidable alerts; leave a next step. [12,B4]

08 Recall then check

Return to learning over time. [14,15,B5]

09 Notice difficult thoughts

Make room for feelings; seek support when needed. [17,B6]

10 Leave room for people

Choose safe, supportive connection. [18,B7]

Choose what helps. You are allowed an unfinished day.

Ideas have origins and limits

[B1] Atomic Habits / James Clear / 2018
Cues, environment, small starts and identity as a helpful frame.

[B2] Tiny Habits / BJ Fogg / 2020
Easy actions attached to existing routines; notice a satisfying finish.

[B3] Protocols An Operating Manual for the Human Body / Andrew Huberman / 2026
Practical sleep, light and focus questions, independently checked here.

[B4] Deep Work / Cal Newport / 2016
Protect time for demanding, meaningful tasks.

[B5] Make It Stick / Peter C Brown, Henry L Roediger III and Mark A McDaniel / 2014
Recall, feedback and spaced learning.

[B6] The Happiness Trap / Russ Harris / 2007; revised 2022
ACT inspired ways to notice thoughts and act on values.

[B7] The Good Life / Robert Waldinger and Marc Schulz / 2023
Make room for supportive relationships.

These books supply starting ideas, not scientific proof. This manual uses original writing, fictional scenes and original diagrams. It does not reproduce book pages, covers, signature diagrams or substantial passages.

Full book texts were not available for complete review. Public author or publisher descriptions and independent scientific sources informed selection. No named author, institution or publisher endorses this manual.

Cold exposure remains uncertain for general wellbeing. [19] Supplement stacks, dopamine resets, fixed coffee delays and elaborate routines were not established as necessary additions in this review.

Created with AI assistance for education. The exact four-week sequence has not been tested as a programme. Publication and source-use records accompany this edition. Rights may differ across jurisdictions.

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